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Strike a Pose

SOONI TARAPOREVALA'S SERIES DEBUT *WAACK GIRLS* ON PRIME VIDEO SHINES A LIGHT ON THE STREET DANCE STYLE OF WAACKING

Filmmaker Sooni Taraporevala never intended to be the "patron saint" of dance but it's how she may come across with Amazon Prime Video's *Waack Girls*, a series which follows the formation of an all-women waacking dance crew in Kolkata. It's her second dance project after *Yeh Ballet* (2020), a Netflix film inspired by the true story of two Mumbai boys who aspire to perform with renowned companies abroad. "It's entirely coincidental," says Taraporevala, best known as the screenwriter of Mira Nair's *Mississippi Masala* (1991) and *The Namesake* (2006) and for her beloved directorial debut *Little Zizou* (2008). "I discovered Mekhola and through her discovered waacking."

Mekhola is Mekhola Bose, a waacking practitioner from Kolkata, who also happens to be the granddaughter of the legendary actor Soumitra Chatterjee. Bose, who had a supporting part in *Yeh Ballet*, enlightened Taraporevala about the dance which traces its origins to the gay clubs of Los Angeles in the 1970s. Best known for its series of stylised arm-over-the-head movements and poses struck with attitude, waacking has made its way into mainstream culture. (Check out Korean band New Jeans' track 'Super Shy' and ice dancers Gabriella Papadakis and Guillaume Cizeron's 2022 Olympic gold medal-winning rhythm dance routine to get familiar with the sassy style). Taraporevala felt there was a story worth telling, not just about the dance but also about an artist's struggle to make ends meet pursuing a passion and about sisterhood.

WAACKING TRACES ITS ORIGINS TO LOS ANGELES'S GAY CLUBS IN THE 1970s, AND HAS MADE ITS WAY INTO MAINSTREAM CULTURE





ARM ARTISTRY Right, Sooni Taraporevala; below, a still from *Waack Girls*

A practitioner for a decade now, Bose never imagined she'd be headlining a show about a dance she learned through the internet. "I wanted to find something that sets me apart and searched for different styles. There was already somebody better than me at every style so I went with waacking," says Bose who has also been a drummer and part of a breaking crew. The fact that waacking started out by being performed to disco music, a favourite genre of hers, drew her even more to the dance. Lean, strong and expressive, Bose has become a force to reckon with, with her viral appearances in *Red Bull Dance Your Style*.

While Bose knew how to waack, at least two members of the crew—Priyam Saha and newcomer Ruby Sah—had to pick up the style from scratch. Much like in the show, Bose acts as the tutor as well as the choreographer. South Korea's waacking exponent Yoonji Lee was roped in to choreograph with set pieces while Shiamak Davar's assistants helped with further training as well as with the shooting dance segments. *Waack Girls* is a rarity in India's streaming landscape in that it's a show centred around dance. It's not entirely fluid but it's sincere in its quest to shine a light on a performing art that's still unfamiliar to the masses. Says Bose, "We don't have too many platforms like this so I'm excited about more people knowing about it. The series will inspire hope and courage in dancers' hearts to pursue this." ■

–Suhani Singh

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